# Send Your Name to Titan on NASA's Dragonfly Mission

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We may still be some time away from sending humans to the distant reaches of the solar system, but you can send your name to Saturn's moon Titan, thanks to NASA's Dragonfly mission.

NASA is asking the public to send their names to Titan for an ambitious mission that will see a flying craft explore the Saturn moon in 2034, if all goes according to plan. The agency opened a special events page in late October to allow members of the public to put their name on the spacecraft. The names will be placed on a chip on Dragonfly during the spacecraft's assembly, and all names must be submitted before January 15, 2027.

Dragonfly is an SUV-sized, **nuclear-powered rotorcraft** that NASA aims to launch toward Titan in 2028. The agency says the mission has no "ordinary itinerary," as Dragonfly aims to fly between areas miles apart after arriving on the surface in 2034. "Nearly a billion miles away, an extraordinary destination awaits. Titan has an atmosphere, rivers and lakes, seasons, sweeping dunes and a landscape rich in **organic material**," NASA officials wrote on the event page. "Upon arrival in 2034, Dragonfly will fly from place to place on this intriguing world to uncover clues about this remarkable moon, and the chemistry that could help us understand the ingredients for life."

Dragonfly will be one of just a few flying crafts on another world. The first was NASA's plucky Ingenuity mini-helicopter, which arrived on Mars along with the still-running Perseverance rover in 2021. Ingenuity was only designed to make five flights, but made it to 72 before its blades were damaged during a landing on January 18, 2024.

Dragonfly, however, is not the first mission to Titan. That would be Huygens, which operated for just a few hours on January 14, 2005, after deploying from the Cassini spacecraft. Huygens was the first lander on an outer solar system world, and it measured Titan's atmosphere and took data from the surface. For its part, Cassini flew by Titan more than 100 times before the mission concluded in September 2017, providing valuable long-term data about the moon from above.

Dragonfly aims to show the moon from up close for about 3.3 Earth years. Its destinations will include dunes and a young **impact crater** called Selk. "Dragonfly is expected to make one flight every one to two Titan days, which is called a **Tsol** and lasts about 16 Earth days," NASA officials added. "Dragonfly will stop at a variety of geologic sites, where it will collect samples of surface material for analysis inside the **rotorcraft** by a suite of scientific instruments." Dragonfly's goals include learning more about **prebiotic chemistry**, the conditions before life arises in a location, and figuring out if Titan had habitable conditions in the past.

## Word Treasure

**rotorcraft** -- A flying craft that lifts off using spinning blades, like a helicopter.

**nuclear-powered** -- Powered by energy from atoms, which keeps working far from the Sun.

**prebiotic chemistry** -- The chemistry that happens before life begins in a place.

**Tsol** -- One Titan day, which lasts about 16 Earth days.

**impact crater** -- A round hollow in the ground made when a space rock hits a moon or planet.

**organic material** -- Material made of carbon-based chemicals, the kind living things are built from.

## Background you need

Titan is the largest moon of Saturn and one of the most interesting worlds in the solar system, because it has a thick atmosphere and liquid on its surface, something no other moon is known to have.

A rotorcraft is a flying machine that uses spinning blades to lift off and land, which lets it visit many different places instead of staying in one spot.

Space agencies sometimes invite the public to send their names on a mission, placing them on a small chip carried by the spacecraft as a way of sharing the journey.

Dragonfly follows earlier visitors to Titan, including a lander that touched down there and an orbiter that flew past the moon many times, and it will study the moon's chemistry up close to learn about the conditions that could lead to life.

## Break it down

**LEAD:** NASA is inviting the public to send their names to Saturn's moon Titan aboard the Dragonfly mission.

**KEY EVENT:** Dragonfly, a nuclear-powered rotorcraft, will launch in 2028 and arrive on Titan in 2034.

+- WHO: NASA and members of the public who submit their names before January 15, 2027.

+- WHAT: Names will ride on a chip aboard Dragonfly, which will fly between sites collecting samples.

+- WHERE: Titan, Saturn's moon, including dunes and the young impact crater Selk.

+- WHEN: Launch in 2028, arrival in 2034, about 3.3 Earth years of exploration.

+- WHY: To study prebiotic chemistry and learn whether Titan had habitable conditions in the past.

**EVIDENCE:** Earlier missions -- Huygens landed in 2005 and Cassini flew by Titan more than 100 times -- showed Titan has an atmosphere, rivers, lakes, seasons, and dunes.

**OPEN QUESTION:** Whether Titan's chemistry can reveal the ingredients for life.

## Why it matters

Dragonfly will explore a distant world up close for years, and what it finds about the chemistry before life could change how we think about where life can begin.

## Test what you remember

1. **By when must names be submitted to fly to Titan on Dragonfly?**
   - (A) June 1, 2028
   - (B) January 18, 2024
   - (C) January 15, 2027
   - (D) October 31, 2026
2. **When does NASA aim to launch Dragonfly toward Titan?**
   - (A) 2025
   - (B) 2027
   - (C) 2026
   - (D) 2028
3. **How long is one Titan day, called a Tsol?**
   - (A) About 72 hours
   - (B) About 16 Earth days
   - (C) About one Earth year
   - (D) About 3 Earth days
4. **What was the first flying craft on another world?**
   - (A) Cassini
   - (B) Huygens
   - (C) Dragonfly
   - (D) Ingenuity
5. **How many flights did Ingenuity make on Mars?**
   - (A) More than 100
   - (B) 18
   - (C) Five
   - (D) 72
6. **Which of these is one of Dragonfly's planned destinations on Titan?**
   - (A) A lake on Mars
   - (B) The top of Mount Everest
   - (C) A young impact crater called Selk
   - (D) The dark side of the Moon

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: B 4: D 5: D 6: C

# Questions to think about

## MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):